

Coping strategies for surviving the wait, grounding techniques, managing catastrophic thinking — Action Checklist

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CALMING BREATH WORK

- ☐ **Sit in a chair and press your feet firmly into the floor before you begin breathing, because your nervous system responds to physical anchors when it cannot find enough data to feel safe, and feeling grounded gives your alarm system somewhere to settle.:** Sit in a chair and press your feet firmly into the floor before you begin breathing, because your nervous system responds to physical anchors when it cannot find enough data to feel safe, and feeling grounded gives your alarm system somewhere to settle.
- ☐ **Breathe in through your nose for four counts, hold for four counts, then exhale slowly through your mouth for four counts, because the extended exhale directly activates your parasympathetic nervous system and signals to your body that it is safe to calm down.:** Breathe in through your nose for four counts, hold for four counts, then exhale slowly through your mouth for four counts, because the extended exhale directly activates your parasympathetic nervous system and signals to your body that it is safe to calm down.
- ☐ **Count each breath phase out loud during the exercise, because counting is a tactile anchor that forces your brain to track something real and immediate, and you cannot count and catastrophize at the same time.:** Count each breath phase out loud during the exercise, because counting is a tactile anchor that forces your brain to track something real and immediate, and you cannot count and catastrophize at the same time.
- ☐ **Redirect your attention back to counting whenever your mind drifts into catastrophic scenarios mid-breath, simply noticing and returning to four without judgment, because each redirect builds a neural pathway that eventually makes the pattern automatic.:** Redirect your attention back to counting whenever your mind drifts into catastrophic scenarios mid-breath, simply noticing and returning to four without judgment, because each redirect builds a neural pathway that eventually makes the pattern automatic.

RAPID SENSORY GROUNDING

- **Use the 5-4-3-2-1 grounding technique in rapid mode at the first sign of a spiral by naming five things you can see out loud, because speaking grounds you more than thinking silently and this rapid version can interrupt the loop before it accelerates.:** Use the 5-4-3-2-1 grounding technique in rapid mode at the first sign of a spiral by naming five things you can see out loud, because speaking grounds you more than thinking silently and this rapid version can interrupt the loop before it accelerates.
- **Name four physical sensations you can feel right now by pressing your feet into the floor and touching objects around you, because engaging your sense of touch anchors you in your actual body and yanks your brain back from the ICU it has mentally visited.:** Name four physical sensations you can feel right now by pressing your feet into the floor and touching objects around you, because engaging your sense of touch anchors you in your actual body and yanks your brain back from the ICU it has mentally visited.
- **Create a personal toolkit that includes your specific triggers for each technique, such as using 4-4-4 before checking your phone for results and 5-4-3-2-1 at 2am when you wake with racing thoughts, because you need a plan you can actually deploy when your hands are shaking.:** Create a personal toolkit that includes your specific triggers for each technique, such as using 4-4-4 before checking your phone for results and 5-4-3-2-1 at 2am when you wake with racing thoughts, because you need a plan you can actually deploy when your hands are shaking.
- **Practice the 4-4-4 breathing pattern twice daily when you are not panicking, so your nervous system learns the rhythm and can access it automatically at 3am when you need it most, because regulation skills must be rehearsed in calm moments to work in crisis moments.:** Practice the 4-4-4 breathing pattern twice daily when you are not panicking, so your nervous system learns the rhythm and can access it automatically at 3am when you need it most, because regulation skills must be rehearsed in calm moments to work in crisis moments.

BUILDING YOUR TOOLKIT

- **Recognize that your catastrophic thoughts are not a weakness but a normal threat-detection response to uncertainty, because understanding that your brain is trying to protect you removes the shame that makes anxiety worse and opens space for actual regulation.:** Recognize that your catastrophic thoughts are not a weakness but a normal threat-detection response to uncertainty, because understanding that your brain is trying to protect you removes the shame that makes anxiety worse and opens space for actual regulation.

- ☐ **Accept that you cannot think your way out of a body-based panic state, because when your nervous system is in alarm mode your prefrontal cortex goes partially offline and rational thinking cannot override the survival signal.:** Accept that you cannot think your way out of a body-based panic state, because when your nervous system is in alarm mode your prefrontal cortex goes partially offline and rational thinking cannot override the survival signal.

- ☐ **Use the 4-4-4 breathing technique immediately before walking into the doctor's office or waiting for a call with results, because the countdown creates a small gap between the trigger and your reaction that prevents the full panic spiral.:** Use the 4-4-4 breathing technique immediately before walking into the doctor's office or waiting for a call with results, because the countdown creates a small gap between the trigger and your reaction that prevents the full panic spiral.

- ☐ **Build your toolkit with physical anchors you can touch and sensory cues you can name, because your body needs grounding cues that work with your nervous system rather than against it, and these cues give your alarm system somewhere concrete to settle.:** Build your toolkit with physical anchors you can touch and sensory cues you can name, because your body needs grounding cues that work with your nervous system rather than against it, and these cues give your alarm system somewhere concrete to settle.

Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.